

## ON TECHNIQUE

### Folk song in classical music

Consisting of repeated verses of unaccompanied melody, folk song, by its nature, operated differently from the developmental processes of classical musical tradition, in which the young Vaughan Williams was highly trained. The same was true of the masterworks of early English choral music, whose intricate melodic workings were unlike the “symphonic” style that dominated 19th-century orchestral writing. Vaughan Williams was able to bring these different resources together, so that a folk-influenced style became the foundation of his own masterly sequence of large-scale symphonies.

The son of a country vicar, Ralph Vaughan Williams was brought up in Surrey by his widowed mother and assorted aunts in a well-to-do, progressively minded family related to Charles Darwin. Music and a wide range of reading were encouraged, and Ralph played the piano and the violin, while also making early attempts at composing. He studied at Cambridge University and the Royal College of Music, before settling in London, where he worked as a church organist and choral conductor, and as music editor of the English Hymnal.

“ There is **no difference in kind**, but only in **degree**, between **Beethoven** and the **humblest singer of a folk song**. ”

RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS, IN NATIONAL MUSIC